

# Comparative Measuring

Using one part as a unit to measure the whole

Comparative measuring is the foundational proportional method. Pick one part of the subject — often the head, or a key unit of length — and use it as a repeatable ruler to establish every other measurement in the drawing.

## KEY CONCEPTS

### The Unit

Choose a reference unit: the height of the head, the width of the torso, the length of one finger. Hold your pencil at arm's length, close one eye, and measure the unit against your reference. This is your yardstick.

### Plumb Lines

A plumb line is a vertical reference line dropped from a key point. It tells you what is directly above or below something else. 'The left knee aligns vertically with the chin.' Essential for accuracy.

### Horizontal Alignments

Use horizontal sighting lines to find what aligns across the figure. 'The bottom of the ear aligns with the bottom of the nose.' These relationships create an invisible grid that structures the drawing.

### Checking Your Work

After placing major landmarks, check them against your reference unit. Does the torso measure 2.5 heads? Does the arm reach to mid-thigh? Use measuring to check — not as the only way to draw.

## PRACTICE EXERCISES

1. Draw a figure, measuring every proportion against the head height. Aim for the 8-head canon.
2. Draw a still life, using the tallest object as your reference unit.
3. Draw a portrait, using the eye width as the base measuring unit.

## FURTHER READING

### ■ Proko – Figure Proportions

<https://youtu.be/nJ6QivnCQgg>

### ■ Proko – How to Measure

<https://youtu.be/C8XGCeIJzXE>